

IndiaScholarships — pSEO & Routing Architecture Review

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Executive Summary

- Long-tail intent strategy is directionally correct — students search hyper-specific queries (deadlines, eligibility, documents), not broad terms like “scholarships.”
- Current design would auto-generate ~4,000–6,000+ URLs on day one. Volume itself isn't the risk — templated near-duplicate content at that volume is.
- Google's March 2026 core update explicitly penalized “scaled content abuse”: sites publishing large volumes of templated pages with only variable substitution saw 60–90% ranking drops.
- Verdict: launching the full 7-subpage × 336-scholarship (+ state) matrix as-is is a strong candidate for that penalty. Fix is tying subpage generation to genuine data depth and staging the rollout — not abandoning the model.

1. Scale Overview

Estimated URL count by cluster, based on 336 scholarships and ~36 states/UTs:

Route Cluster	Pattern	Est. URL Count
Scholarship detail pages	/scholarships/:slug	336
Scholarship pSEO subpages	/scholarships/:slug/:subpage (×7)	2,352
State hub pages	/scholarships-in/:state	~36
State hub pSEO subpages	/scholarships-in/:state/:subpage (×7)	~252
Category / Level / Income / Course / University hubs	various	Uncapped — not yet sized
Total (core clusters only)		~2,976+

2. Key Risks

Risk	Description	Why It Matters
Templated near-duplicates	Many subpages (e.g. income-limit, documents-required) likely share near-identical government boilerplate with only the scholarship name swapped.	Matches Google's named violation: “pure template with variable substitution.” Benchmark for survival is ≥500 unique words/page with 30–40% content variance; sub-300-word pages carry elevated deindexation risk.
State-hub subpages don't map to real intent	Concepts like renewal-process or apply-online aren't meaningful at a state-	Risks being either thin/empty or a re-aggregation of scholarship-level content

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	aggregate level — they're per-scholarship.	with no new value — the “aggregator with no added context” pattern Google flagged.
Inconsistent URL taxonomy	No shared prefix pattern across hubs (scholarships-for, scholarships-by-course, scholarships-level, scholarships-income); overlapping paths (/state-scholarships vs /scholarships-in/:state).	Creates duplicate/competing pages for the same query and dilutes internal link equity across near-identical hubs.
Weak internal linking / crawl depth	Architecture only shows top-down links (hub → detail → subpage); no defined lateral linking.	Deep subpages (3 levels from home) risk becoming orphaned or crawl-starved, hurting indexation even if content quality is fine.
No conditional generation logic	All 7 subpages appear to generate for every scholarship regardless of whether the DB record has distinct data for that topic.	Guarantees a percentage of the 2,352 scholarship subpages will be thin or duplicate by construction, not by accident.

3. Recommendations

Priority	Action	Rationale
1	Generate a subpage only when the DB record has genuinely distinct data for that topic; otherwise fold it into the parent detail page as an anchor section.	Removes thin/duplicate pages at the source instead of publishing and hoping they rank.
2	Stage the rollout: launch full subpage clusters for the top 50–100 highest-search-volume scholarships first (human-reviewed), noindex the rest, expand in batches.	Mirrors how surviving programmatic-SEO sites handled the March 2026 update — avoids a mass thin-content signal at launch.
3	Add FAQPage / HowTo structured data on consolidated detail pages for eligibility, apply-online, etc.	Can win the long-tail snippet without needing a dedicated thin URL for every micro-query.
4	Add visible E-E-A-T signals per page: “last verified” date, direct link to the official notification PDF, editorial attribution.	Primary counter-signal against being classified as a content aggregator.
5	Fix internal linking so hub pages link down to every child and detail pages cross-link laterally (same state, same category).	Prevents orphaned deep subpages and distributes crawl/link equity properly.
6	Standardize the URL prefix taxonomy; eliminate the /state-scholarships vs /scholarships-in/:state overlap before launch.	Removes duplicate/competing pages for the same query intent.

Sources

- Scaled Content Abuse: Google's AI Page Crackdown Guide — digitalapplied.com

- [Programmatic SEO After March 2026: Scaled Content Survival — digitalapplied.com](#)
- [Understanding Google's Scaled Content Abuse Policy — bulkbase.ai](#)
- [The Ultimate Guide to Google's Scaled Content Abuse Policies — breaklineagency.com](#)
- [Spam Policies for Google Web Search — Google Search Central \(developers.google.com\)](#)
- [How to Build Programmatic SEO Pages That Do Not Get Flagged as Thin — seoguru.ai](#)